The Obsolete Man

By Rod Serling

NOTE: This cutting asks each student portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

Roles: ***Actor 1:*** *Secretary, Romney Wordsworth*
Actor 2: *Narrator, Chancellor*

SECRETARY: Wordsworth, Romney, Obsolescence. *(A feeble man walks through two large doors. As the two doors close, he is led by a guard to his microphone. His eyes have a look of confusion, awe, and fear as he looks around the word. The Narrator's voice comes over the scene.)*

NARRATOR: You walk into this room at your own risk, because it leads to the future; not a future that will be, but one that might be. This is not a new world: It is simply an extension of what began in the old one. It has patterned itself after every dictator who has ever planted the ripping imprint of a boot on the pages of history since the beginning of time. It has refinements, technological advancements, and a more sophisticated approach to the destruction of human freedom. But like every one of the super states that preceded it, it has one iron rule: Logic is an enemy, and truth is a menace. This is Mr. Romney Wordsworth, in his last forty-eight hours on Earth. He's a citizen of the State, but will soon have to be eliminated, because he's built out of flesh and because he has a mind. Mr. Romney Wordsworth, who will draw his last breaths in the Twilight Zone.

INTRODUCTION

Actor 1: *The Obsolete Man by Rod Sterling*

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CHANCELLOR: Wordsworth, Romney. You've been under investigation, Mr.Wordsworth, for the mandatory period of 1 year and 11 months. You are found to be obsolete. Your occupation, Mr.Wordsworth?

WORDSWORTH: A librarian, sir. . .

CHANCELLOR: *(Puzzled and angrily)* The field investigators in your sector have classified you as obsolete, this finding carries with it serious implications. Do you understand that, Mr.Wordsworth? *(Wordsworth nods)* I'd ask you again, your occupation Mr.Wordsworth?

WORDSWORTH: I AM a librarian, that IS my occupation, that is my PROFESSION. If you people choose to call that obsolete . . .

CHANCELLOR: A librarian. Having to do...with books.

WORDSWORTH: *(Proudly)* Yes sir . . . books!

CHANCELLOR: Since there are no more books, Mr.Wordsworth, there are no more libraries, and, of course, as it follows , there is very little call for the services of a librarian. Case in point: A minister. A minister would tell us that his function is that of preaching the word of God. And since it follows that since The State has proven that there is no God. That would make the function of a minister quite academic as well . . .

WORDSWORTH: There IS a God!! *(The Chancellor looks angry)*

CHANCELLOR: You are in error, Wordsworth. There is NO GOD! *(To the audience)* The STATE HAS PROVEN THAT THERE IS NO GOD!!

WORDSWORTH: You cannot erase God, with an edict!

CHANCELLOR: You are obsolete, Mr.Wordsworth!

WORDSWORTH: A lie, no man is obsolete! I am nothing more than a reminder to you that you cannot destroy truth by burning pages!

CHANCELLOR: You're a bug, Mr.Wordsworth. A crawling insect. An ugly, misformed, little creature, that has no purpose here, no meaning!

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WORDSWORTH: I am a human being...

CHANCELLOR: You're a librarian, Mr.Wordsworth. You're a dealer in books and two cent finds and pamphlets in closed stacks in the musty finds of a language factory that spews meaningless words on an assembly line. WORDS, Mr.WORDSworth. That have no substance, no dimension, like air, like the wind. Like a vacuum, that you make believe have an existence, by scribbling index numbers on little cards.

WORDSWORTH: I don't care. I tell you: I don't care. I'm a human being, I exist....and if I speak one thought aloud, that thought lives, even after I'm shoveled into my grave.

CHANCELLOR: Delusions, Mr.Wordsworth, DELUSIONS!! That you inject into your veins with printer's ink, the narcotics you call literature: The Bible, poetry, essays, all kinds, all of it are opiate to make you think you have a strength, when you have no strength at all!!! You are nothing, but spindly limbs and a dream, and The State has no use for your kind!!!! *(Calming down)* You waste our time, Mr.Wordsworth, and you're not worth the waste. Ladies and Gentlemen, how do you find?

SECRETARY: Romney Wordsworth, Step forward. *(Wordsworth steps forward)* The board finds you obsolete.

CHANCELLOR: Your rights are as followed, Mr.Wordsworth, you are to be liquidated within a period of 48 hours, but you have an option as to method and precise time. There are several prescribed methods, Mr.Wordsworth: pills, gas, electrocution...and it can be done immediately, or an hour from now, or any specific time you request.

WORDSWORTH: I choose the following: to be given an assassin to whom I shall tell the method of my execution . . .

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CHANCELLOR: That would be acceptable Mr. Wordsworth, provided that you are eliminated within the 48 hour period.

WORDSWORTH: Oh, yes...and one final request . . . I should like to die . . . with an audience.

CHANCELLOR: Ahhh, Mr.Wordsworth *(looking gleeful)* that can be arranged indeed. It is not unusual that we televise executions, it has an educative effect on the population.

WORDSWORTH: I have no doubt . . .

CHANCELLOR: Now as to the time of the liquidation, Mr.Wordsworth?

WORDSWORTH: Midnight. . . In my room . . .

CHANCELLOR: Agreed, Mr.Wordsworth. We will choose your liquidator and send him over to you. He will be duty bound not to divulge the method you have decided upon. That will be all Mr.Wordsworth. You may leave and return to your room. *(The Doors open back up as Wordsworth walks out.)* We will show the people how this . . . obsolete man . . . this librarian . . . dies . . .

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Setting: Wordsworth's apartment. A knock is heard on his door and Wordsworth proceeds to open it. Revealing the Chancellor standing in the doorway, smiling . . .

WORDSWORTH: Come in Chancellor. *(Chancellor steps in and Wordsworth locks the door as The Chancellor stares into the room of books and pamphlets that he so hates)* Thank you for coming . . .

CHANCELLOR: Very irregular, Mr.Wordsworth. You know why I've come, do you?

WORDSWORTH: Well, I invited you.

CHANCELLOR: Well, of course you invited me, but why would I honor such an invitation, a cryptic note sent by a condemned man asking me to visit him in the last hours of his life. Hardly the norm, Mr.Wordsworth. Hardly what I'm accustomed to .

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. . and somewhat suspect too . . . how do I know I wasn't invited for that pitiful gesture of vengeance on the part of the condemned . . .

WORDSWORTH: Vengeance . . . ?

CHANCELLOR: Yes . . . I'm somewhat responsible for the finding in your case. Your . . . demise in less than an hour can attributed to my decision.*(Pause)* I'll tell you why I came here. To prove to you that The State has no fears, none whatsoever . . .

WORDSWORTH: *(laughing)* Forgive me Chancellor, that has the elements of a joke . . . I mean you come to MY room to prove that The State . . . isn't afraid of me!? Why what an incredible burden I must be! For The State to have to prove that isn't afraid of an obsolete librarian like myself. No, I'll tell you the reason you came...I tell you the reason even though you won't admit it to yourself. . . I don't fit your formuli. Your state has everything categorized . . . indexed, TAGGED. People like you are the strength, people like me are the weakness. You control order and dictate and my kind . . . merely follow and obey. But something has gone wrong hasn't it? I don't fit, do I?

CHANCELLOR: Yes, you fit, Mr.Wordsworth! Indeed, you fit! In a few minutes, you'll be cringing and pleading just like they all do! You have a worthless meaningless little life, but you also have an instinct for survival. And in a few minutes when you feel life slipping away. When you feel that your survival is just a question of minutes, we'll see then which is stronger, Mr.Wordsworth, The State or the librarian! *(pause)* I take it you've had a talk with whoever has assigned your liquidation.

WORDSWORTH: Yes, you see they brought this equipment here earlier this afternoon . . . *(A TV Camera is shown built into the wall with two large lights built next to it)* It's remote control, very efficient. *(The Camera and lights click on)* Why, we're being televised now.

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CHANCELLOR: It's not unusual that we televise executions, Mr.Wordsworth . . . last year in the mass executions, we televised around the clock. *(Proudly to the cameras)* Thirteen hundred people were put to death in less than six hours.

WORDSWORTH: You never learn do you? History teaches you nothing!

CHANCELLOR: On the contrary. History teaches us a great deal. We had predecessors, Mr.Wordsworth, that had the beginnings of the right idea . . .

WORDSWORTH: Ah, yes, Hitler!

CHANCELLOR: Yes, Hitler. Stalin, too. But their error was not one of excess it was simply not going far enough! Too many undesirables left around and undesirables eventually create a corp of resistance. Old people for example, clutch at the past and won't accept the new. The sick, the maimed, the deformed, they fasten onto the healthy body and damage it. So WE eliminate them! And people like yourself, they can perform no useful function for The State, so . . . we put an end to them. *(walks around, sarcastically admiring the decor around him)* You aren't facing the camera, Mr.Wordsworth. You're cheating your audience. They'll want to see how you die. Please, face the camera, Mr.Wordsworth. *(Wordsworth looks at the cameras with a sly grin on his face, The Chancellor kneels next to him, rubbing his hands together hoping to break Wordsworth but he keeps his sly look)* That's right, and don't stifle your emotions, if you feel like crying, go ahead and cry, and if you feel like pleading, by all means plead. Some high State official might take pity on you.

WORDSWORTH: Yes, that would please you wouldn't it? A little abject hand wringing, chest pounded, falling down on my hands and knees . . .

CHANCELLOR: Suit yourself, Mr.Wordsworth. Unfortunately, I won't be able to be entertained by them when they do come. I have another appointment this evening. *(Chancellor heads toward the door)*

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WORDSWORTH: Chancellor . . . You have plenty of time. You're not going anywhere! *(Stops and turns around)* I'm afraid I haven't been very fair with you. I invited you here for a very special reason. Would you like to know the method I have chosen for my liquidation? Well, in a few moments, here in this room a bomb is going off. *(Chancellor tries to open the door and finds that it is locked)*

CHANCELLOR: What kind of idiocy is this, Mr.Wordsworth? You've locked the door. *(Chancellor is now scared)*

WORDSWORTH: Oh yes, yes, I've locked the door . . . now question *(turns to cameras to address the question at the nation-wide audience):* How does a man react to the knowledge that he's going to be blown to bits in a half an hour? Answer: *(turning back to Chancellor)* that depends on the individual. As for me, I'm going to sit down *(heads towards safe in his room and pulls a grubby, old, Bible,)* and read my Bible. *(Wordsworth clutches his Bible like a lost treasure. The Chancellor is slowly moving towards him as if unsure how it would look in front of the cameras to force him to open the door and then stops)* It's been hidden here for over twenty years, it's a crime punishable by death, so it's only thing I have that has any value at all to me . . . So I'm just going to read it . . . until the moment of my death. How will you spend your last moments, Chancellor.

CHANCELLOR: *(Trying to hide his fear)* This is insane Wordsworth let me out of here! *(Heads to door and tries to open it)* Let me out of here, guards, someone!

WORDSWORTH: You're cheating the audience. You aren't facing the camera . . . and there's no sense in raising your voice. There's nobody there, that's one of the rules you made up yourself. Isolate the person to be liquidated. That's what you said! . . . so why don't you face the camera. It's important, you said so yourself. *(Chancellor begins to break, hands rubbing together, but hides it from the camera's broadcast. But then turns around)*

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CHANCELLOR: I'm beginning to understand, Wordsworth, shoe on the other foot, that's the idea. It's one thing for somebody like yourself, to do a little cringing and pleading, but what a choice opportunity to show a member of The State doing likewise. But you're insane, Wordsworth, if you think they'll let me stay here!

WORDSWORTH: They? Ah, you mean The State! Oh, I think they'll sit on their hands for a while. They wouldn't want to miss this scene. Besides the act of rescue would be very demeaning to them, to have to break in here and rescue a high ranking member of The State, to snatch him out of the soup, so to speak. Oh, I think "They" won't help you. . . You underestimated me. You wanted to the whole world, to see the way a librarian dies. Well, let them see, how an official of The State dies too. Face the camera, step into the light! *(The Chancellor, obeys knowing he must not prove himself to be a coward, but the fear is still evident in his glare at Wordsworth) (to the camera)* So here you have this strong, handsome, uniformed, bemedaled symbol of giant authority and this little, insignificant, librarian . . . and suddenly in the eyes of God . . . there is precious little to distinguish us . . . *(The Chancellor looks toward the door as if expecting to be rescued.)*

CHANCELLOR: We shall see, Wordsworth, we shall see . . . *(He faces the cameras) (Wordsworth calmly reads passages from various books of the Bible with no fear on his face, the camera's broadcasting every word and image.)*

WORDSWORTH: The lord is my shepherd I shall not want. He maketh me to lie down in green pastures. He leadeth me beside the still waters. He restoreth my soul . . . By rod and by staff they come for me. Thou preparest a table before me in front of mine enemies. Thou annointest my head with oil. My cup runneth over. Surely, goodness and mercy shall follow me all the days of my life . . . *(Tears are swelling up in the Chancellor's eyes and he weeps out of fear. Wordsworth is still calmly reading to him as he breaks)* Out of the depths, have I called unto

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thee, O Lord. Lord hear my voice. Let thine ears be attended to the voice of my suffocations

CHANCELLOR: Please, PLEASE,let me out . . . in the name of God . . . LET ME OUT!!! *(Runs to the door, pulling it)* LET ME OUT, LET ME OUT!!! LET ME OUT!!!

WORDSWORTH: Yes, Chancellor, in the name of God, I will let you out!

(Wordsworth gives him the key) (The Chancellor unlocks the door and runs and hides on the edge of the stairs, in cowardly fear. Wordsworth, in his room, sighs and closes his eyes and accepts his fate as the camera broadcasts the explosion across the country as it sets off, killing Wordsworth instantly. The Chancellor walks away in tears of fear.)

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Setting: The Board Room - (The Chancellor, now all clean walks into the board room only to stop in shock at seeing his secretary dressed as he is in his podium, in the chancellor's garments. Below him at the foot of the podium is another secretary.)

SECRETARY: Stand right where you are! No further! You have been removed from office, the field investigators have declared you obsolete.

CHANCELLOR: Obsolete!?

SECRETARY: You have disgraced The State. You have proven yourself a coward. You have therefore, no function . . . you are OBSOLETE!

CHANCELLOR: But I'm not . . . I'm NOT obsolete.

SECRETARY: You are obsolete!

CHANCELLOR: You're making a terrible mistake. A tragic mistake. I'm not obsolete!! I glory The State, I carry the State, I give The State strength! How can you call me obsolete! HOW CAN YOU!!! Please . . . I'm not obsolete . . . *(whimpering)* Please .. I have a function, I have a purpose *(begins to gently weep)* NOOOOO!!! PLEASE, I'M NOT OBSOLETE!!!!! NOOO!!!!!

NARRATOR: The chancellor, the late chancellor, was only partly correct. He was obsolete, but so is the State, the entity he worshiped. Any state, any entity, any ideology that fails to recognize the worth, the dignity, the rights of man, that

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state is obsolete. A case to be filed under "M" for mankind—in the Twilight Zone.

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AWARD HISTORY

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